

Populism and Conspiracy

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Abstract: This article examines the relationship between populism and conspiracy discourse, arguing that populism operates through an “anti-conspiracy conspiracy.” Populist actors denounce conspiracy theories as irrational or politically dangerous while presenting their own accounts of hidden elites, foreign interference, and institutional betrayal as vigilant realism. Drawing on the Albanian case, particularly the political rhetoric surrounding Edi Rama and the 2025 TikTok ban, the article shows how accusations of conspiracy can delegitimize opponents and justify restrictions on dissent. It then explores the connection between populism and fascism, focusing on the aestheticization of politics, the leader’s performance as guardian of the nation, and the use of spectacle, myth, and discipline to produce political authority. The article argues that contemporary populism occupies both sides of conspiracy discourse and increasingly turns political style into a claim about truth.

Keywords: Albanian studies, political science, edi rama, albanian leadership, biography

Populism in the Balkans, just like in the United States, has presented itself as the one exposing the real conspirators — “the elites,” “the bankers,” “the system” — while simultaneously denying that it engages in conspiracy talk.⁵ This anti-conspiracy conspiracy talk denounces only one conspiracy (the corrupt elites’ plots, the “4th Reich,” the cabals in Brussels).

Populism often uses the label of “conspiracy theory” as a weapon against opponents. In Greece, for instance, right-wing anti-populists accused SYRIZA of trafficking in conspiracies about Germany, the EU, or austerity. SYRIZA in turn sometimes threw the same label back at ND (the conservatives). In this sense, populist struggle is framed by what Markou calls the polemical use of the term: branding your rival’s discourse as “mere conspiracy” discredits them in public debate.

So while some scholars argue that populism naturally breeds conspiracism (because of its Manichean worldview), Markou flips the lens: Populism casts itself as the guardian of truth against the conspiracy of conspiracists.

The word “conspiracy” becomes a floating signifier: a rhetorical weapon used to delegitimize rivals, while your own suspicion of hidden powers is recast as vigilance, realism, or patriotic duty.

In short, populism thrives by occupying both sides of the conspiracy discourse: it disavows conspiracy thinking as such, yet insists that only it sees through the “real” conspiracy that others conceal. That’s why we can describe it as an anti-conspiracy conspiracy.

⁵Grigoris Markou, “Is Conspiracism Endogenous to Populism? A Discursive-Theoretical Analysis,” *Redescriptions: Political Thought, Conceptual History and Feminist Theory* 25, no. 2 (2022): 154–170. <https://doi.org/10.33134/rds.376>.

Populism as an Anti-Conspiracy Conspiracy

The populist use of tropes such as conspiracy theories plays an increasingly important role in their politics. Populism and conspiracy theories present a number of common traits – Manichaeism, a sense of victimhood, and an ambivalence towards representative politics – and populists’ use of conspiracy theories is politically purposeful. Targeting a conspiring elite serves to vilify real or fictional opponents and/or shield populists from hostile attacks. Looking at three cases of populists in government – Orbán in Hungary, Trump in the United States, and Chávez in Venezuela – we examine the definition of conspiring elites (who), the circumstances under which conspiracy theories are propagated (when), and the ultimate purpose of conspiratorial framing (why).

Populists in power use conspiracy theories to demonise and delegitimise their opponents, to promote or prolong a sense of crisis, and to rally support while distracting from possible failure.

If populism is defined as an ideology/ideation or as a political style/rhetoric, there is a direct or indirect correlation between populism and conspiracy theories. The correlation is direct when populism embraces conspiracy theories as part of its ideological framework or rhetorical strategy. It is indirect when populism rejects conspiracy theories but still employs similar narratives or tactics to mobilize support.

In the “anti-conspiracy conspiracy” dynamic, populism paradoxically positions itself as both the denouncer and the possessor of conspiracy-busting insight. In Albania, this dual logic takes a recognizable local form. Politicians (notably Prime Minister Edi Rama) have framed the opposition not merely as political rivals, but as a destabilizing force—often implicitly or explicitly suggesting connections to “Russian sources,” borrowing a rhetoric familiar across Eastern Europe in countries like Romania or Bulgaria.

Amid the 2025 electoral cycle, this framing found its most theatrical application: the Rama administration imposed a yearlong ban on TikTok, citing youth protection concerns—specifically, social media-fuelled violence after a fatal stabbing. Critics, however, saw a political motive: a populist move to silence dissent and control information, especially given TikTok’s popularity among younger, opposition-leaning users.⁶⁷

Thus, we observe populism’s reflexive conspiracy logic at play: it condemns conspiracy (that of foreign interference), yet it simultaneously deploys conspiratorial tropes (“Russian-backed destabilizers”) to delegitimize the opposition, while acting to restrict dissenting platforms. Hence, the regime becomes both anti-conspiracist and conspiracist—an *anti-conspiracy conspiracy*.

This logic also turns political authority into a performance of protection. The leader appears as the figure who alone can distinguish genuine threats from manufactured scandals, while emergency measures are presented as evidence of responsibility rather than instruments of control. In this arrangement, the

⁶Albania imposed a one-year ban on TikTok amid claims it was contributing to youth violence—but critics called it censorship aimed at stifling dissent before parliamentary elections in May 2025.

⁷The government’s TikTok ban sparked street protests. Opponents accused Edi Rama’s administration of manipulating access to information and restricting freedom of expression ahead of the elections.

spectacle of defending the public becomes inseparable from the production of an enemy, preparing the ground for a politics in which style, symbolism, and discipline carry as much weight as policy.

Populism and Fascism: Their Connection

Populism and fascism, while distinct, share certain ideological resonances—most notably the mobilization of a “pure people” against perceived enemies—yet they diverge fundamentally in methods and historical scope. As Roger Griffin has argued, fascism represents a revolutionary or “palingenetic” form of ultra-nationalism: it envisions the rebirth of a decaying nation through mobilizing myths and authoritarian leadership, often merging populist appeal with totalitarian ambitions.⁸ By contrast, populism typically operates as a “thin-centered” ideology focused on defending the ordinary people against elites, and does not inherently advocate violence or the dismantling of democratic institutions.⁹

One of the paradoxes in the text is that populism often uses the label of “conspiracy theory” as a weapon against opponents. In Greece, for instance, right-wing anti-populists accused SYRIZA of trafficking in conspiracies about Germany, the EU, or austerity. SYRIZA in turn sometimes threw the same label back at ND (the conservatives). In this sense, populist struggle is framed by what Markou calls the polemical use of the term: branding your rival’s discourse as “mere conspiracy” discredits them in public debate.

So while some scholars argue that populism naturally breeds conspiracism (because of its Manichean worldview), Markou flips the lens: populism can also present itself as the one exposing the real conspirators — “the elites,” “the bankers,” “the system” — while simultaneously denying that it engages in conspiracy talk. The result is an anti-conspiracy conspiracy:

Conspiracy is denounced, but only their conspiracy (the corrupt elites’ plots, the “4th Reich,” the cabals in Brussels).

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“Rama describes politics, in other words, as ‘the highest stage of conceptual art.’”¹⁰

If fascism is defined less as a doctrine than as an aesthetic regime, than Rama’s conceptualization of art certainly fits the definition. Fascism is not

⁸Roger Griffin, *The Nature of Fascism* (London: Routledge, 1991)

⁹Cas Mudde and Cristóbal Rovira Kaltwasser, *Populism: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017)

¹⁰“Politika si art konceptual – Neue Zürcher Zeitung për Edi Ramën,” *Deutsche Welle*, September 17, 2013

an ideology with stable content but a staging that fuses politics, art, and everyday life into a single “total work” of form, ritual, and symbol.¹¹ Mussolini and Hitler repeatedly cast themselves as artists of the state; Goebbels even claimed the Führer had transformed the polity into a *gesamtkunstwerk*. In this rendering, style is not ornament but ontology: the regime “is what it seems,” sustained by rallies, emblems, salutes, and choreographed conduct as much as by laws. Once the show falters, the system frays.

From this angle, Mussolini’s self-presentation is exemplary. He called politics “the highest of arts” because it sculpts living material—people—while promising to restore “style” to modern life, a palette ranging from violence to mysticism. The point was to make social reality wearable, speakable, and seeable: from the ubiquitous littorio to campaigns over pronouns and greeting rituals, behavior itself became a medium. Schmid’s account is equally clear that fascist aesthetics was eclectic—expressionist flourishes, futurist aeropittura, and neo-classical monumentality—so long as the result intensified loyalty and legibility.

This aestheticization of politics meets its mirror in Socialist Realism. In both cases “realism” is not mimetic description but an annihilation of the extant in favor of a model reality—heroic bodies, mythic backdrops, allegorical episodes that prescribe conduct (eugenics in Judgement-of-Paris canvases; the worker-saint in murals). Art does not depict; it makes the world that must be. Hence Schmid’s insistence on allegory and his linkage to Emilio Gentile’s notion of fascism as a political religion, where ritual correctness is as crucial as truth claims. In the same key, Roger Griffin’s “palingenesis” explains the time-alchemy: a modernist project justified as a rebirth of the nation’s archaic essence; Jeffrey Herf’s “reactionary modernism” captures the paradox of machine-age means enlisted for mythic ends. Schmid threads both concepts through his synthesis.

Himmler’s cultural project literalized this sacred-aesthetic frame. The SS chief sponsored revivals of Germanic pagan motifs and rites, not as antiquarian pastiche but as a live grammar for belonging. In Schmid’s terms, such mythic staging provides the only “palpable” surface of institutions that lack functional legitimation; the rite makes the state appear—and appearance is essence.

Read this way, the deep family resemblance between fascist aesthetics and Socialist Realism lies in their shared solution to the problem of belief: dissolve the line between art and politics so that the citizen’s horizon is a single, stylized world. Both are anti-ideological in the sense that doctrine becomes secondary to form—march, banner, anthem, photo-op; tractor, sunburst, worker’s torso, leader’s visage. The result is a unified nationalist project that claims to transcend “mere” ideas by embodying the nation in spectacle.

This is also why neo-nationalism and contemporary populism feel like sequels in new media. The permanent campaign aesthetic—brand palettes, leader-as-producer, mythic pasts compressed into hashtags and massed drone shots—privileges style as political truth and mobilization as meaning. It is not that policy disappears; rather, it is performed into being. The lesson from

¹¹Ulrich Schmid, “Style versus Ideology: Towards a Conceptualisation of Fascist Aesthetics,” *Totalitarian Movements and Political Religions* 6, no. 1 (June 2005): 127–140. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14690760500099758>.

Schmid's analysis is disquieting: when politics becomes art, the test of reality is applause, and the encore is always a promise of national rebirth.